# Common Online Challenges for Local Businesses

A focused improvement plan for busy owners with limited time and resources.

## What you will take away

Separate the problems that prevent contact from the improvements that can wait. Give each issue an owner, a next action and a review date.

## Start with this quick check

- List every place a customer can find or contact you.
- Check that your hours, services, phone number and links agree.
- Trace one enquiry from discovery through to the reply.

Do not change everything at once. Fix a specific, evidenced problem, then check whether the customer journey works better.

# What to check - and why it matters

## 01 Different information in different places

An old phone number, incorrect holiday hours or mismatched service area can leave customers unsure. Keep a simple master record and use it to update the website, Business Profile and important directories. Google recommends complete, accurate business information. [1]

## 02 Too many offers and no obvious starting point

Organise services around customer needs. Put the most relevant choices first, explain who each is for and use plain-English labels. Avoid making visitors understand your internal business structure before they can find help.

## 03 An online presence that is hard to maintain

Reduce duplicated content and unnecessary tools. Document who can edit pages, access domain accounts, renew services and recover logins. Use role-appropriate access and a repeatable update checklist.

## 04 A booking or enquiry hand-off that loses context

Send visitors to the right service or booking destination. Explain when they leave your site for an external platform. Check confirmations and replies, not just the link. Keep form fields labelled and required information clear. [2]

## 05 Content that never answers the buying question

Replace generic claims with service details, examples, clear limitations and answers about process or pricing. Google's people-first guidance prioritises content that benefits readers rather than content made primarily for rankings. [3]

## 06 Reports with numbers but no decision

Decide which event represents progress: a successful enquiry, confirmed booking or relevant call. Check business records as well as analytics. Tracking gaps, consent choices and third-party booking tools can limit what is observable. [4]

# Your practical action plan

## WEEK 1 - Remove contact failures

Check contact details, key links, form delivery and booking confirmations. Give any failure a named owner.

## WEEK 2 - Resolve one clarity problem

Improve one important service page using real customer questions. Add relevant proof and a specific next step.

## WEEKS 3-4 - Build a maintenance habit

Record what changed and why. Review completed enquiries, common customer questions and unresolved issues; adjust the next priority.

Illustrative example: a consultant receives unsuitable enquiries because the website never states who the service is for. A short suitability section and a clearer enquiry question may be a better first change than adding more social posts.

# Make the next step specific

### Most important online failure to investigate:

### One change within our control:

### Who owns the fix and ongoing updates:

### Evidence of improvement and review date:

## Discuss your next step with Joseph

Share your current website and the part of the customer journey that feels difficult. Joseph can discuss a focused improvement scope or ongoing care.

Start a conversation with Joseph

## Research notes and further reading

[1] Google: Improve your local ranking

[2] W3C WAI: Labeling controls

[3] Google: People-first content

[4] Google Analytics: Conversions and key events

Research checked 25 October 2026. Examples are illustrative, not measured client results. Educational guidance, not a full technical, accessibility or legal audit.